WINDOWS 11 ADMINISTRATION LAB • USER TICKET

Local Administrator Sign-in Failure

Troubleshooting and recovering a disabled built-in Administrator account without resetting its password

Ticket → Investigation → Fix → Verification

PREPARED BY

Urvisha Bhoi

Environment
VMware lab, WIN11-WS01 joined testuser.local

Contents

01 **Report Overview** The ticket, the key idea, lab environment

02 **Part A: Setting Up the Lab** Backup admin account, enabling and disabling Administrator

03 **Part B: The Investigation** Sign-in error, Local Users and Groups, permissions

04 **Part C: The Fix** Signing in with an authorized admin and enabling the account

05 **Part D: Final Verification**

06 **Part E: Password Reset and Its Risks**

07 **Command Reference**

08 **What I Learned**

09 **Summary and Security Follow-up**

Report Overview

The ticket

> **ℹ USER REPORT**
> "I can't sign in to WIN11-WS01 with the local Administrator account."

A sign-in failure can look like a forgotten password, but it often is not. Before resetting anything, a technician should find out **why** the sign-in fails. A password reset on a local account is not risk-free: Windows warns it can permanently lock the account out of its encrypted files, saved passwords and certificates.

The key idea: local vs domain accounts

Account type	Where it lives	How to sign in
Local account	Only on that one computer	`.\Administrator`, `.\SupportAdmin`
Domain account	On the domain controller; works on any domain PC	`TESTUSER\ituser02`

The `.\` prefix tells Windows to use an account stored on **this computer**. The sign-in screen confirms it with **"Sign in to: WIN11-WS01"**.

What I did in this project

1. Set up the lab: created a backup local admin account, enabled the built-in Administrator with a password, then disabled it.
2. Confirmed the symptom and investigated as a standard domain user with Local Users and Groups.
3. Proved why the standard user could not fix it, using whoami /groups.
4. Verified the backup admin account two ways before relying on it.
5. Fixed the problem with one change only (enabling the account) and proved the original password still worked.
6. Reviewed, but did not use, the password reset option and its data-loss warnings.

Lab environment

Item	Value
Computer	**WIN11-WS01**, Windows 11 Pro, joined to **testuser.local** (TESTUSER)
Account with the problem	**Administrator** (built-in local administrator)
Standard domain user	**IT User02** (`TESTUSER\ituser02`), not a local administrator
Backup local admin	**SupportAdmin**, member of the local Administrators group

Item	Value
Setup account	**Urvisha** (local admin, used only to prepare the lab)

✓ **RESULT IN ONE SENTENCE**

The built-in Administrator account was disabled, not using a wrong password. Using the authorized local admin account SupportAdmin, I enabled it without resetting the password, and the original password worked immediately.

Part A: Setting Up the Lab

These steps prepared the scenario. They were done as the local administrator **.\Urvisha** in an administrator PowerShell window.

A1. Create a backup local admin account

▸ Run on: WIN11-WS01 (PowerShell as Administrator)

```
PS> net user SupportAdmin * /add
PS> net localgroup Administrators SupportAdmin /add
```

What it does: The first command creates a local account named SupportAdmin; the * makes Windows ask for the password without showing it on screen. The second adds SupportAdmin to the computer's local **Administrators** group.

A2. Enable the built-in Administrator

```
PS> net user Administrator /active:yes
PS> net user Administrator *
```

What it does: `/active:yes` turns the account on. `net user Administrator *` sets its password (typed twice, hidden).

> ⚠ **PROBLEM I HIT: ERROR 2245**
>
> The first attempt to enable the account failed: "The password does not meet the password policy requirements" (NET HELPMSG 2245).
>
> The built-in Administrator on Windows 11 is disabled by default and has **no password**. Because WIN11-WS01 is joined to the domain, the domain password policy applies, and it does not allow an account with a blank password to be activated. I set a password first, then enabled the account successfully.

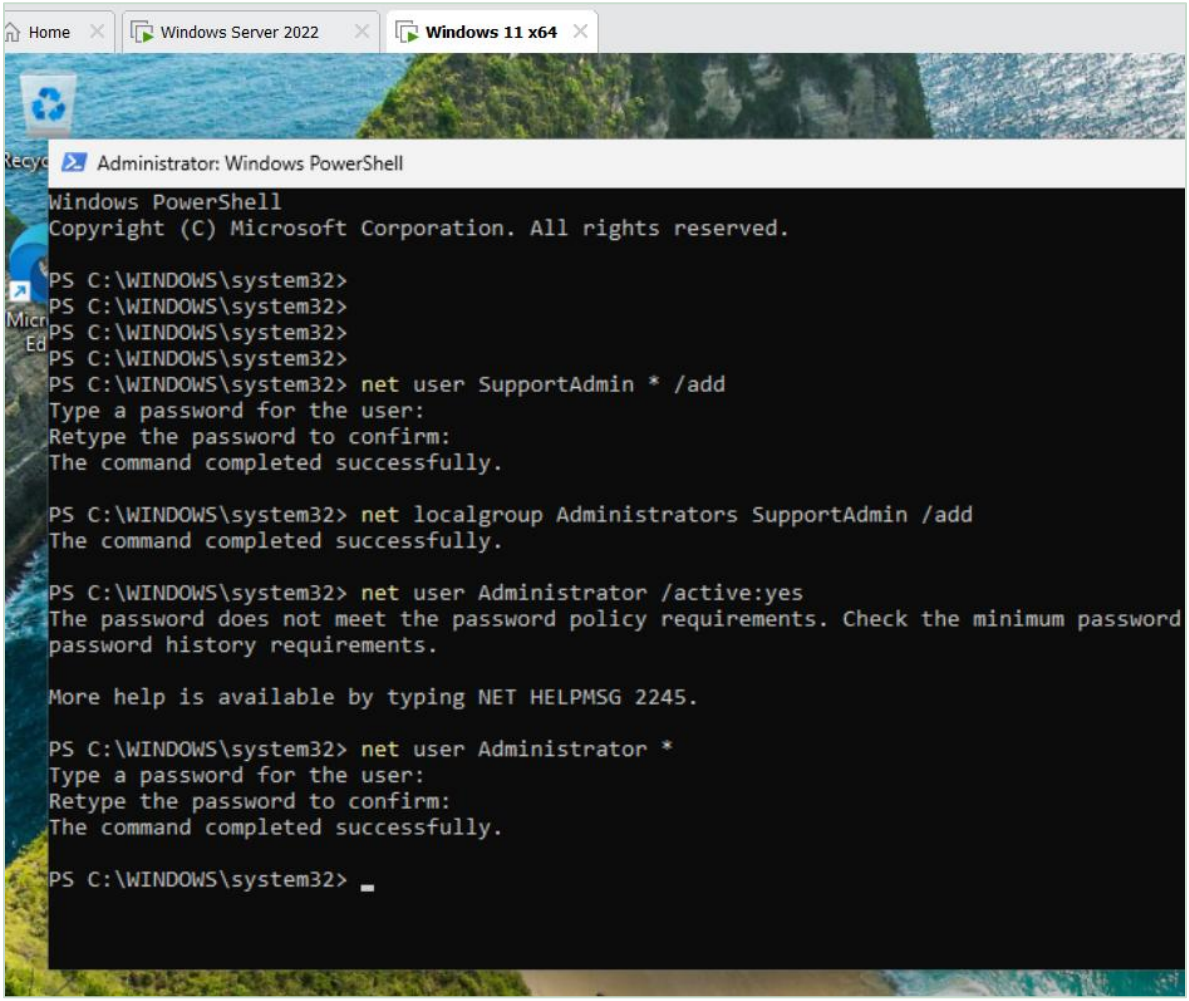


FIGURE 1 *SupportAdmin is created and added to Administrators. Enabling Administrator first fails with error 2245 because the account has no password, so a password is set.*

```
PS> net user Administrator /active:yes
PS> net user Administrator
```

What it does: Enables the account again (now successful) and shows its details.

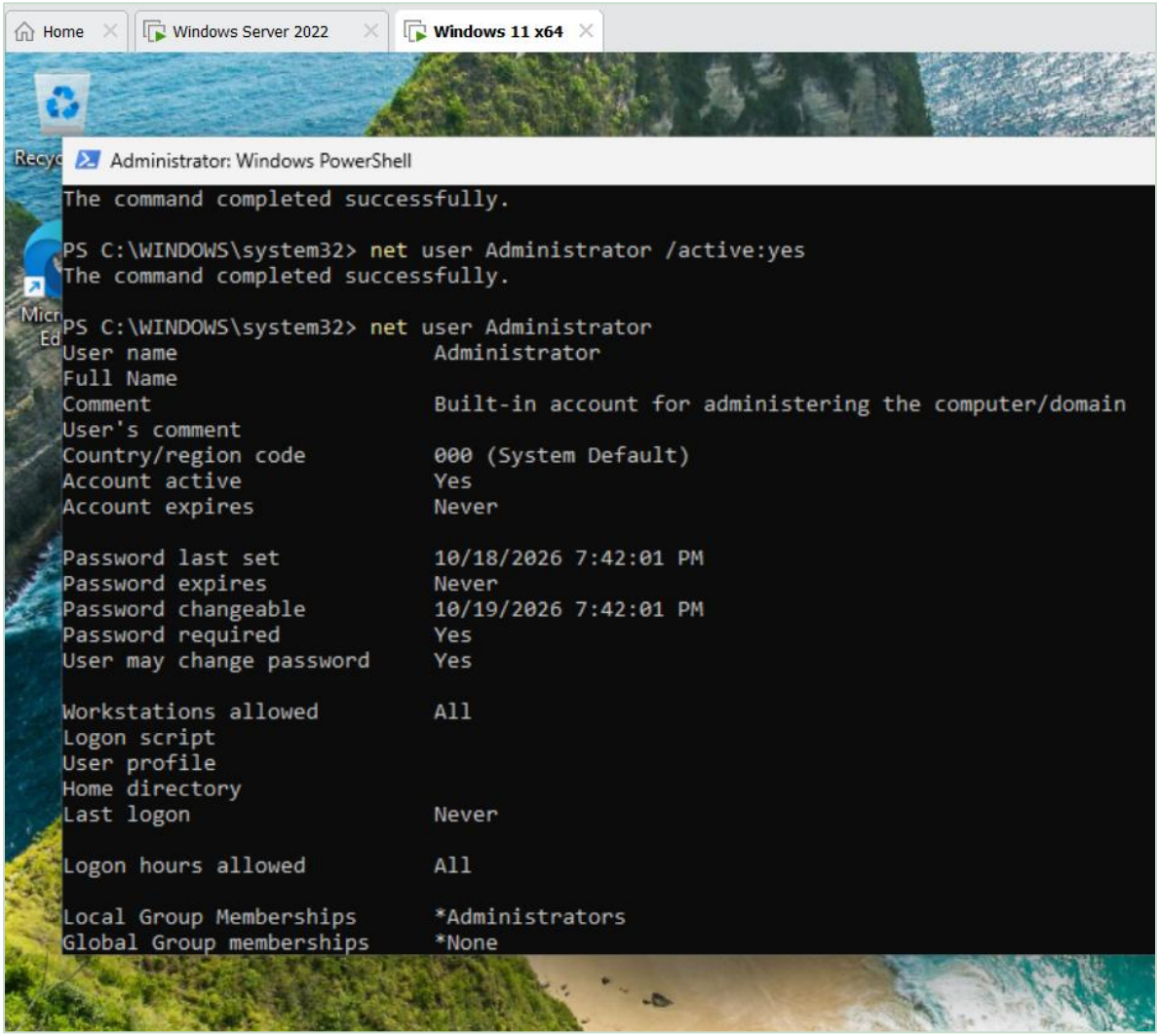


FIGURE 2 *The account is now active (Account active: Yes), a password was set at 7:42 PM, and it belongs to the local Administrators group.*

A3. Plant the problem

```
PS> net user Administrator /active:no
PS> net localgroup Administrators
```

What it does: `/active:no` **disables** the account; the password is not changed. `net localgroup Administrators` lists every member of the local Administrators group.

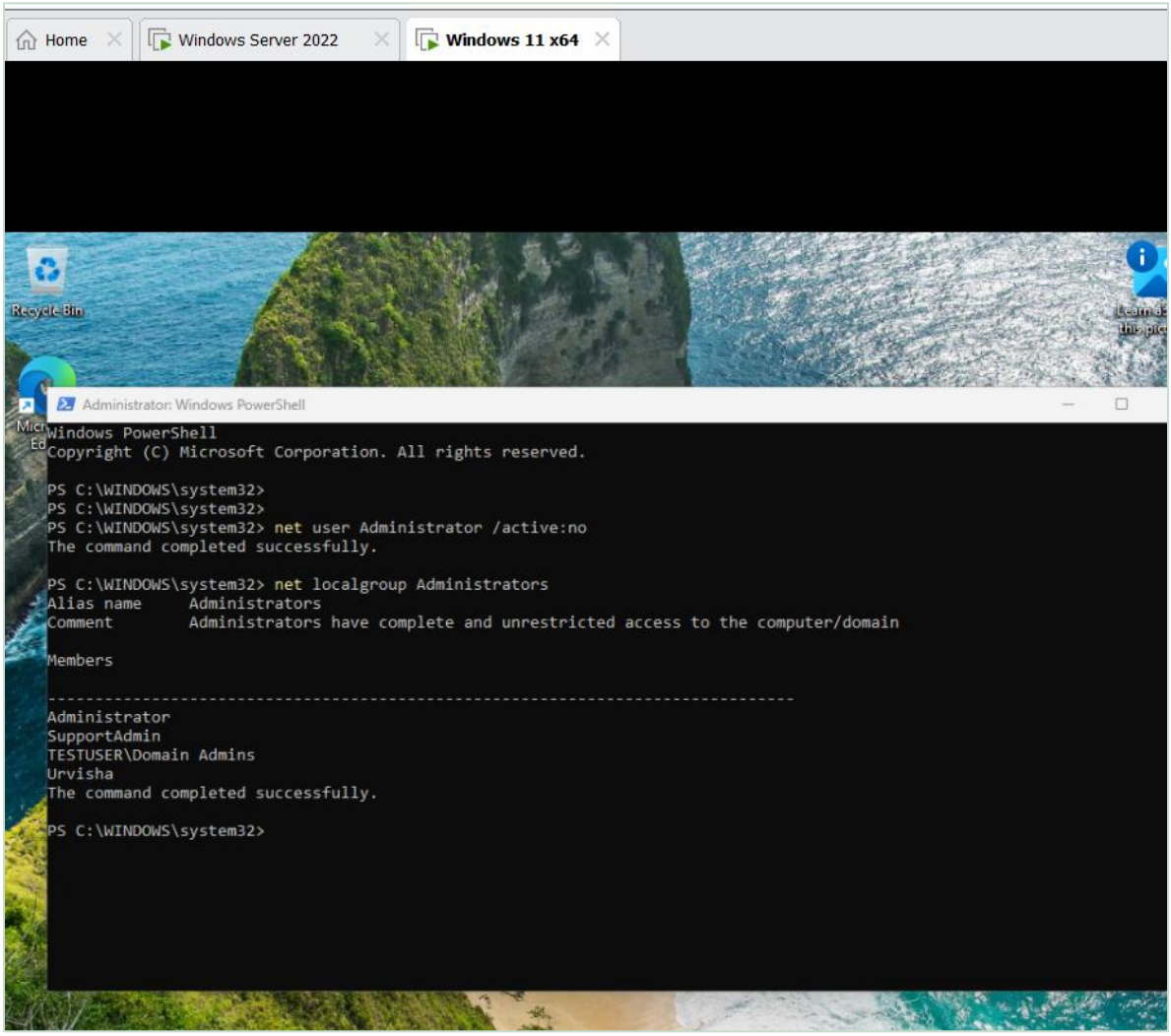


FIGURE 3 *Administrator is disabled. The local Administrators group contains Administrator, SupportAdmin, TESTUSER\Domain Admins and Urvisha, but not IT User02.*

I then took a VMware snapshot named **Admin-Disabled** so the scenario could be repeated.

Part B: The Investigation

From here I worked as the help desk technician with only the ticket to go on.

B1. Confirm the symptom

At the sign-in screen I chose **Other user** and entered **.\Administrator** with its correct password.

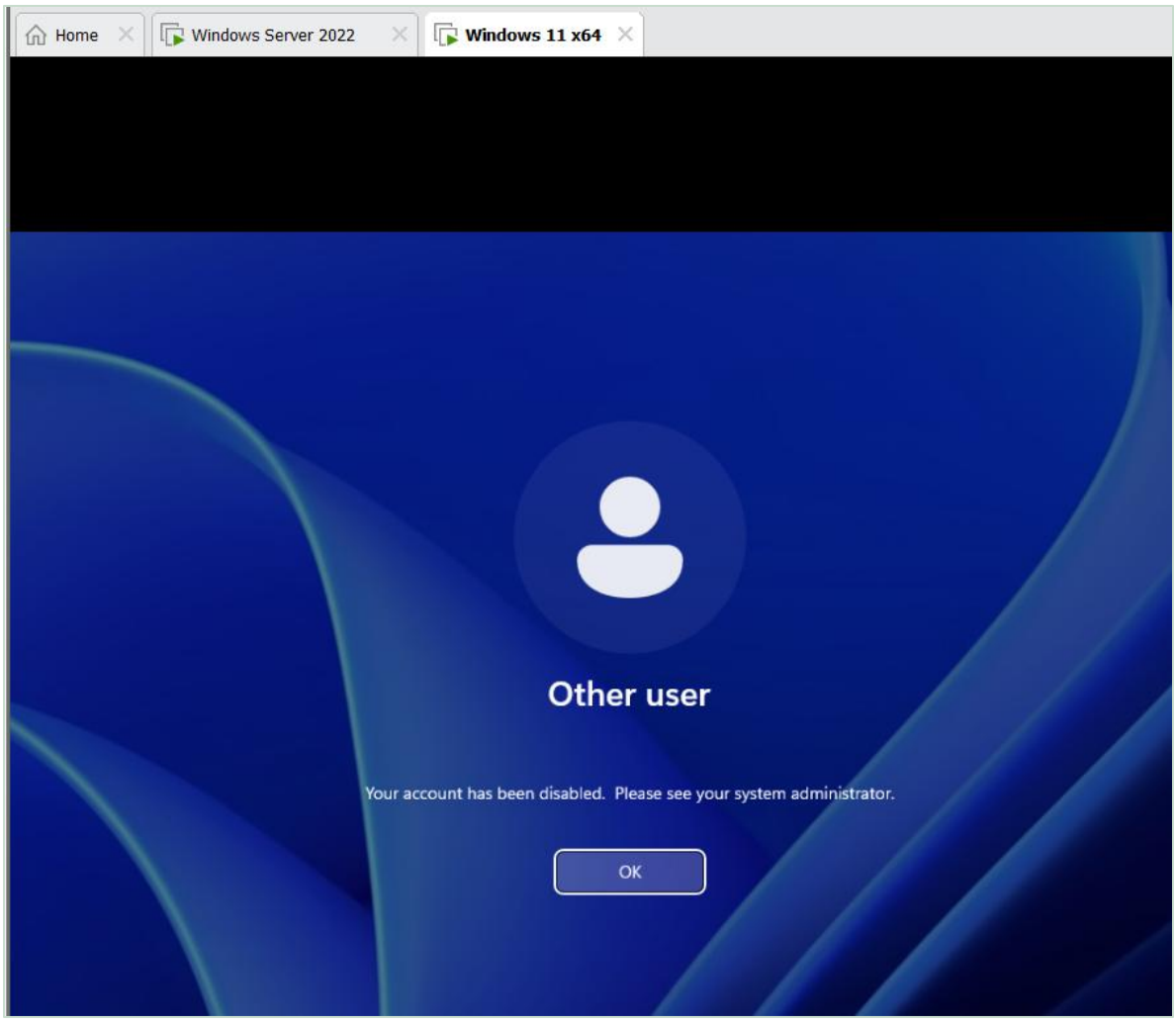


FIGURE 4 *The sign-in fails: "Your account has been disabled. Please see your system administrator."*

> **A CLUE, NOT YET PROOF**
>
> The message already points to a disabled account, but a technician should confirm the account's settings before acting, and check whether the person investigating has permission to fix it.

B2. Open Local Users and Groups as a standard user

I signed in as the domain user **TESTUSER\ituser02**, pressed **Win + R**, typed **mmc**, and chose **File > Add/Remove Snap-in**. I added **Local Users and Groups** and kept **Local computer** (WIN11-WS01) as the target.

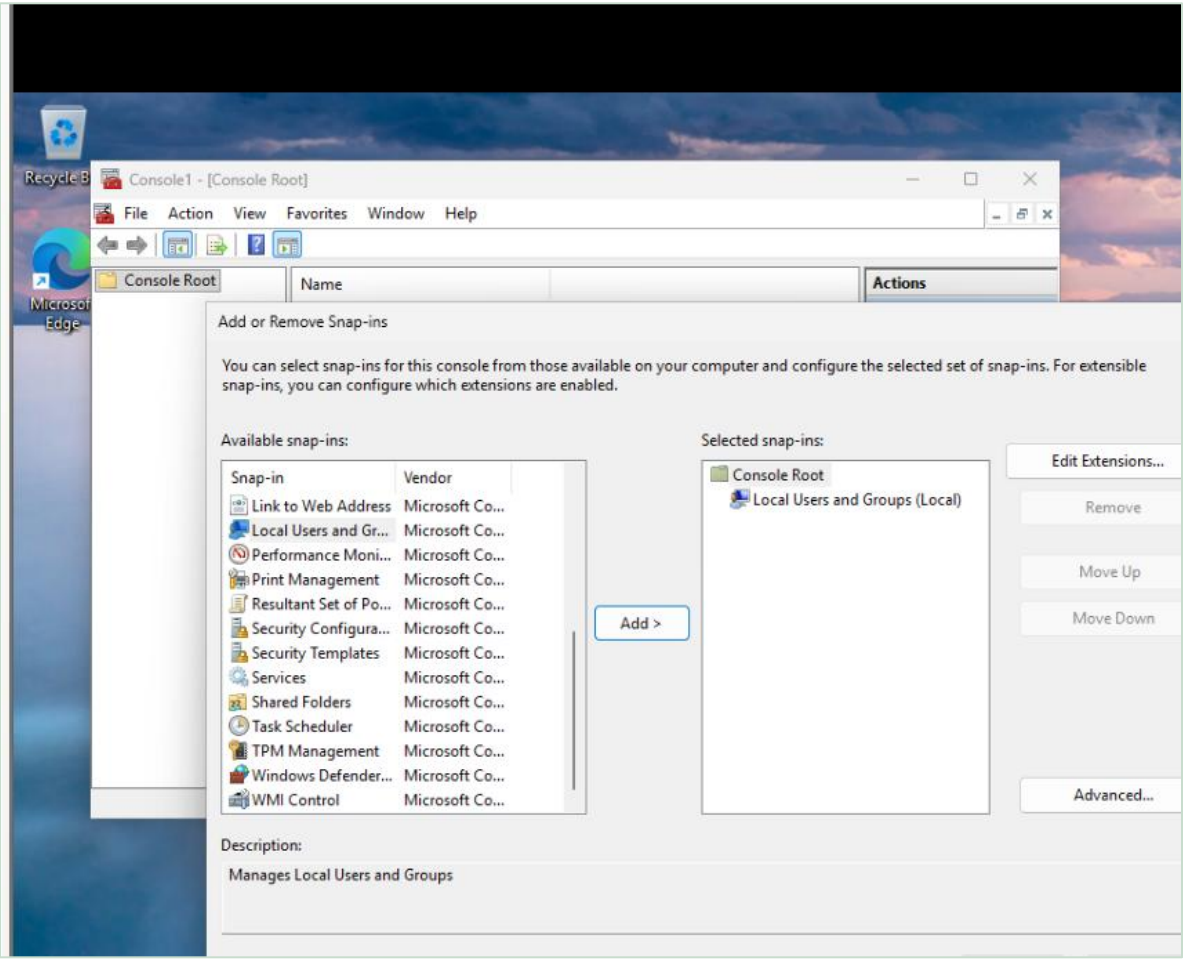


FIGURE 5 *Adding the Local Users and Groups snap-in for the local computer in Microsoft Management Console (MMC).*

> **FASTER WAY**
>
> Win + R > `lusrmgr.msc` opens Local Users and Groups directly, without building an MMC console.

B3. Find the cause

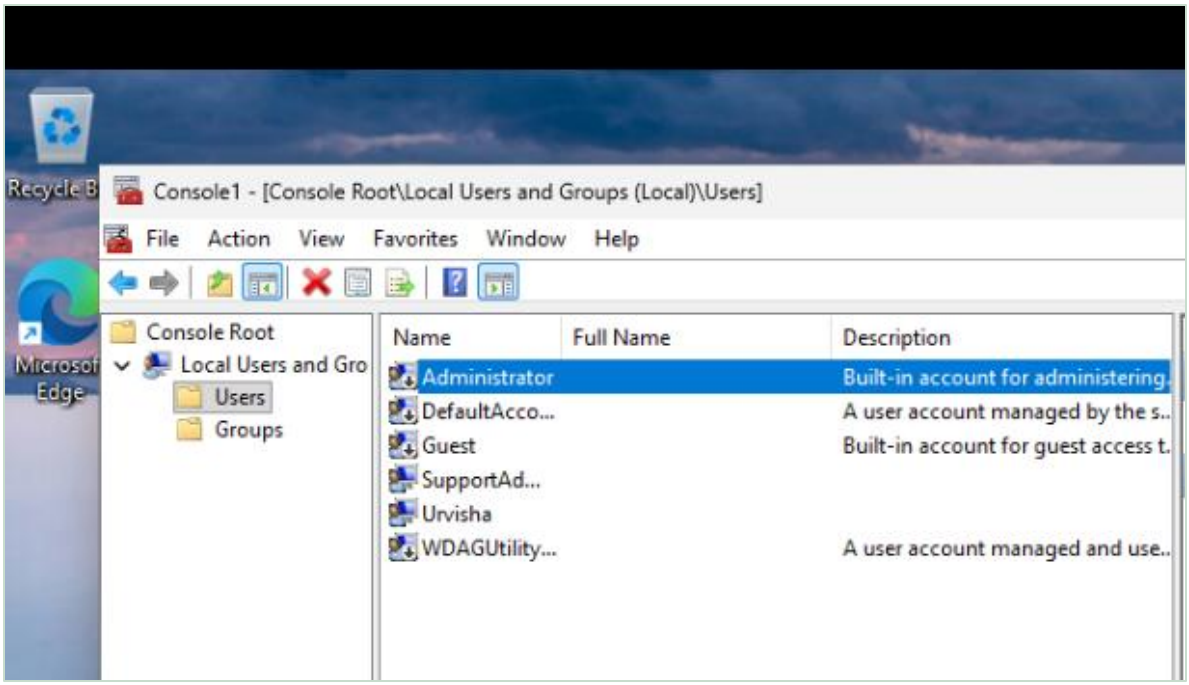


FIGURE 6 *The local accounts on WIN11-WS01. A small down-arrow on an account icon means the account is disabled.*

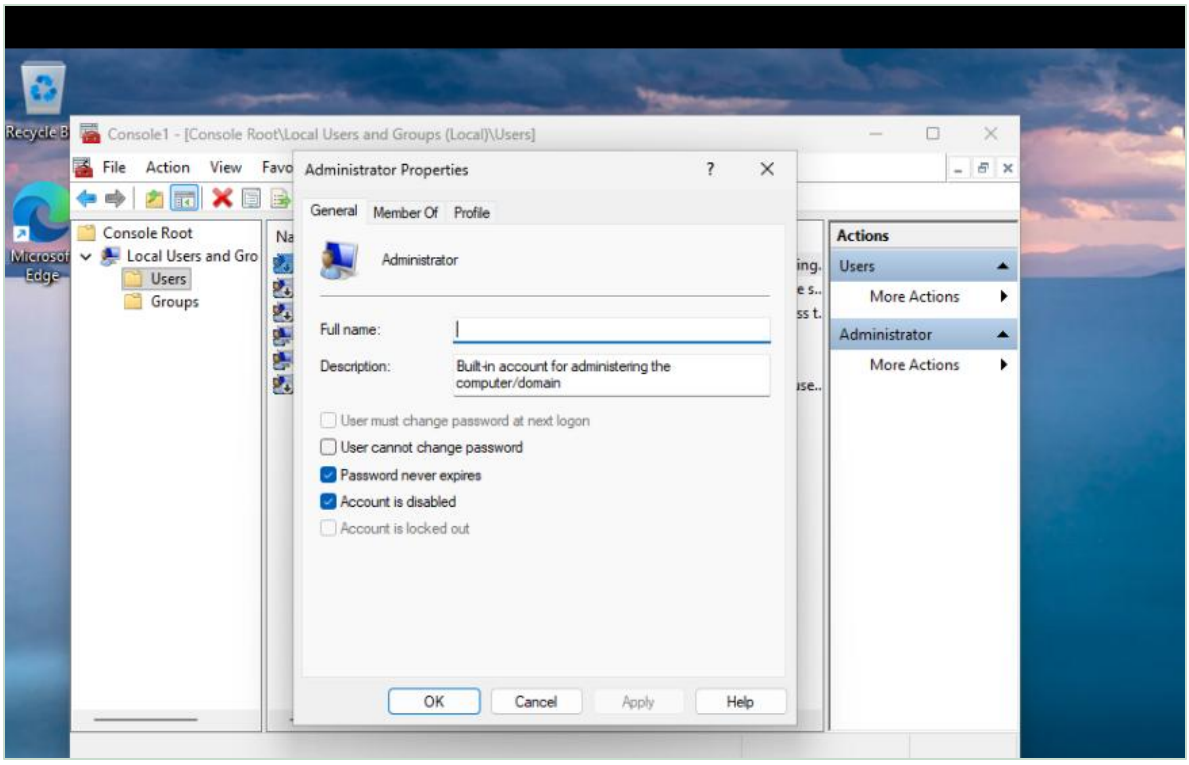


FIGURE 7 *Administrator properties: "Account is disabled" is ticked.*

> ◉ **CONFIRMED CAUSE**
>
> The built-in local Administrator account is **disabled**. Nothing suggests the password is wrong.

B4. Try to fix it as the standard user

I unticked **Account is disabled** and clicked **Apply**.

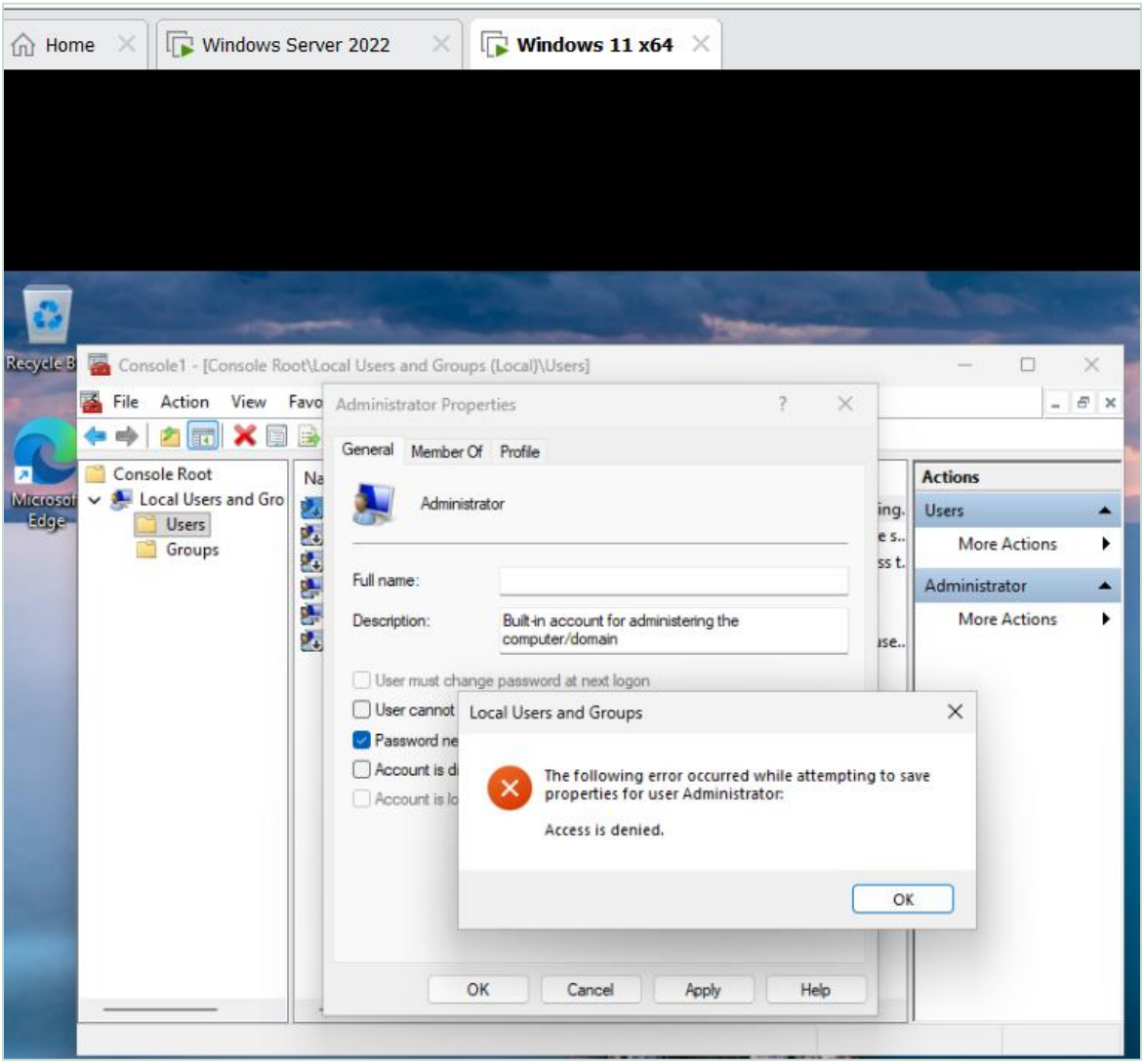


FIGURE 8 *Windows refuses the change: "Access is denied."*

B5. Prove why the standard user cannot fix it

▸ **Run on: WIN11-WS01 (normal Command Prompt as IT User02)**

```
PS> whoami /groups
PS> whoami
```

What it does: `whoami /groups` lists every group the signed-in user belongs to in this session. `whoami` shows the account name.

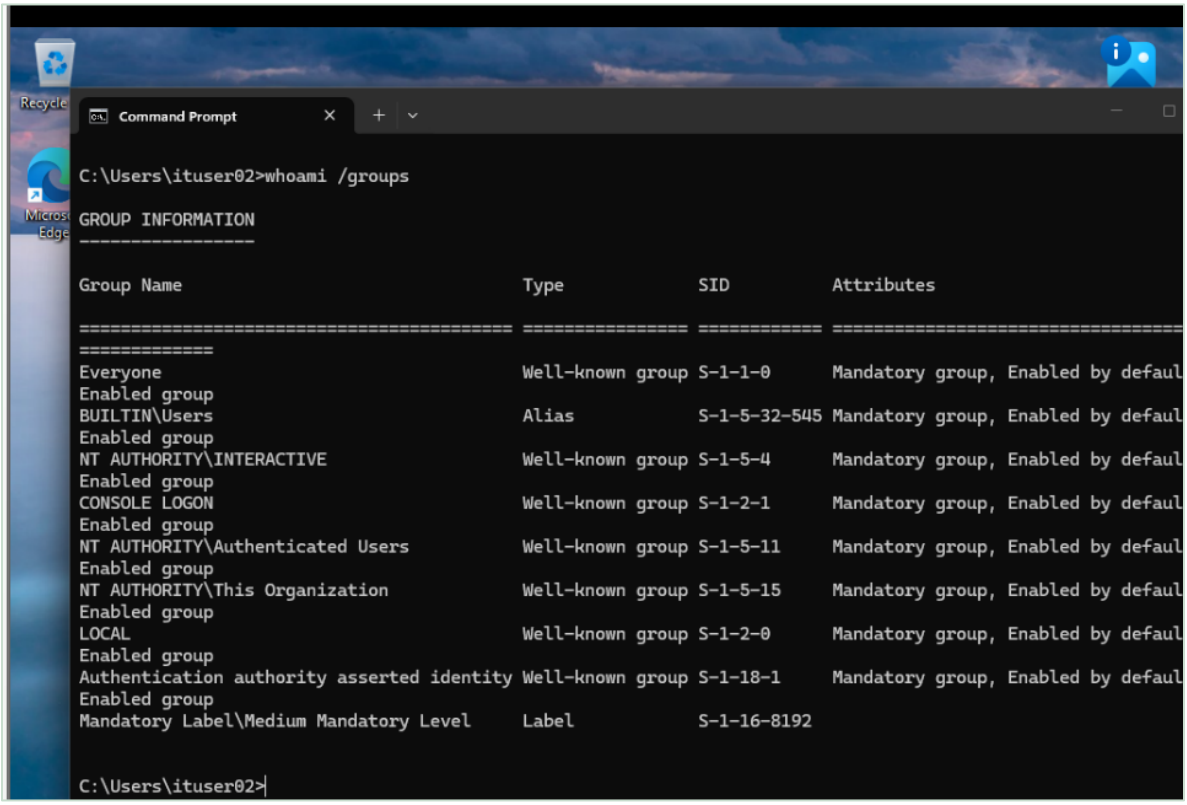


FIGURE 9 *IT User02 belongs to BUILTIN\Users but not BUILTIN\Administrators.*

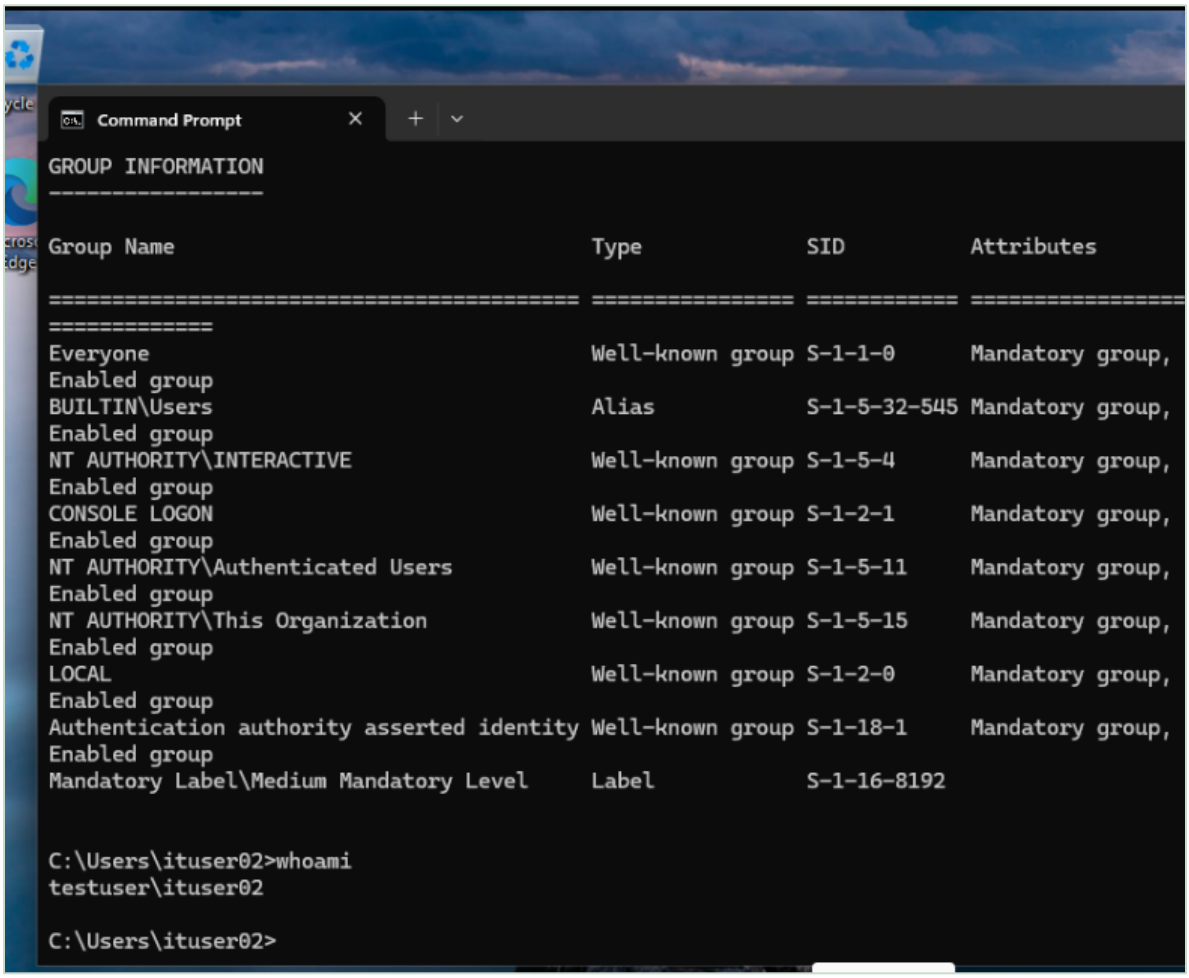


FIGURE 10 *whoami confirms the session belongs to testuser\ituser02, a standard user running at Medium Mandatory Level.*

Group in the output	Meaning
BUILTIN\Users	Standard user on this PC: can use it, cannot change system settings
NT AUTHORITY\INTERACTIVE, CONSOLE LOGON	Signed in at the keyboard
NT AUTHORITY\This Organization	The account comes from this domain
Mandatory Label\Medium Mandatory Level	Normal (not elevated) trust level
BUILTIN\Administrators: missing	No permission to enable or change local accounts, so "Access is denied"

B6. Check the backup admin account

In Local Users and Groups I opened **SupportAdmin**. The General tab showed the account was enabled, and the **Member Of** tab showed **Administrators**.

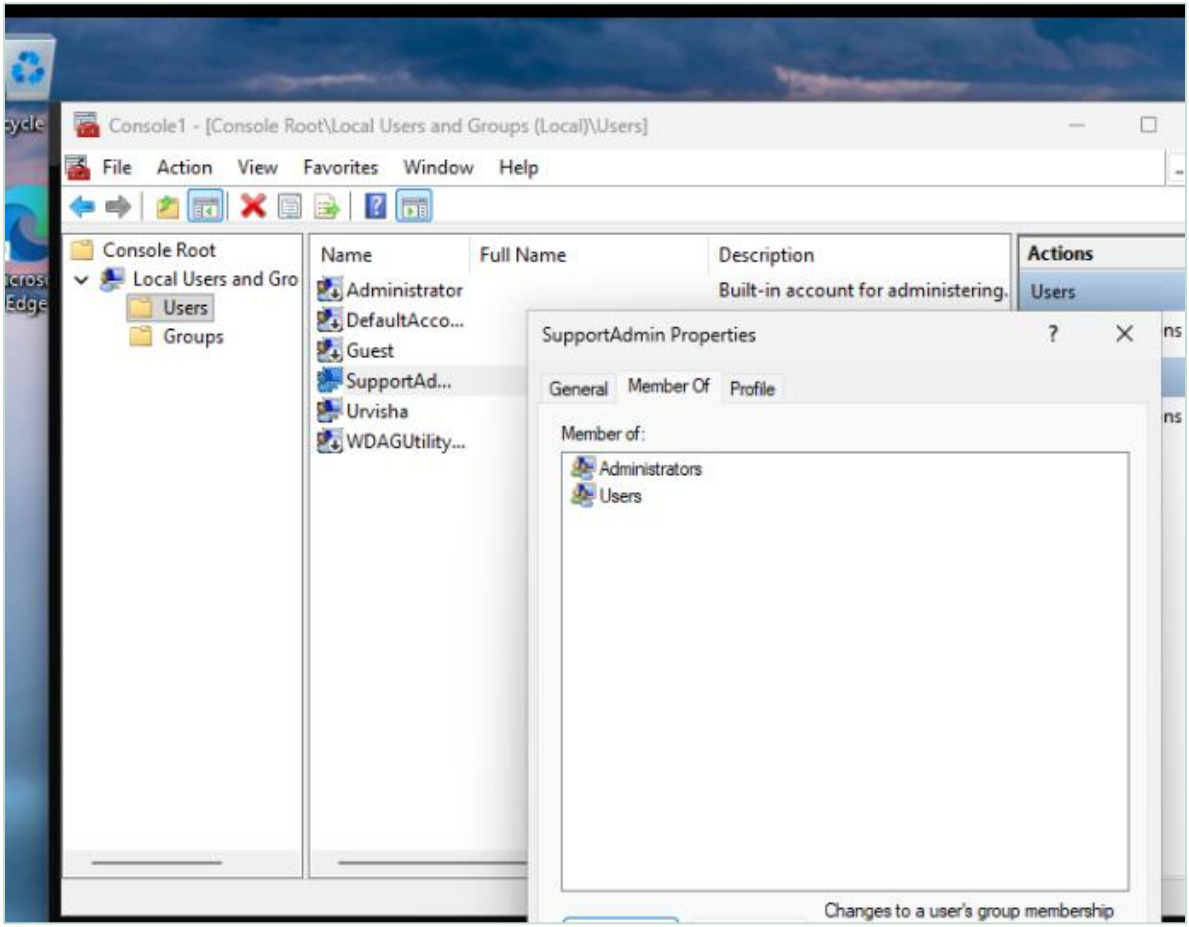


FIGURE 11 *SupportAdmin is a member of Administrators (and Users).*

```
PS> net localgroup Administrators
```

What it does: Confirms the same membership a second way from the command line. A standard user can read this list but cannot change it.

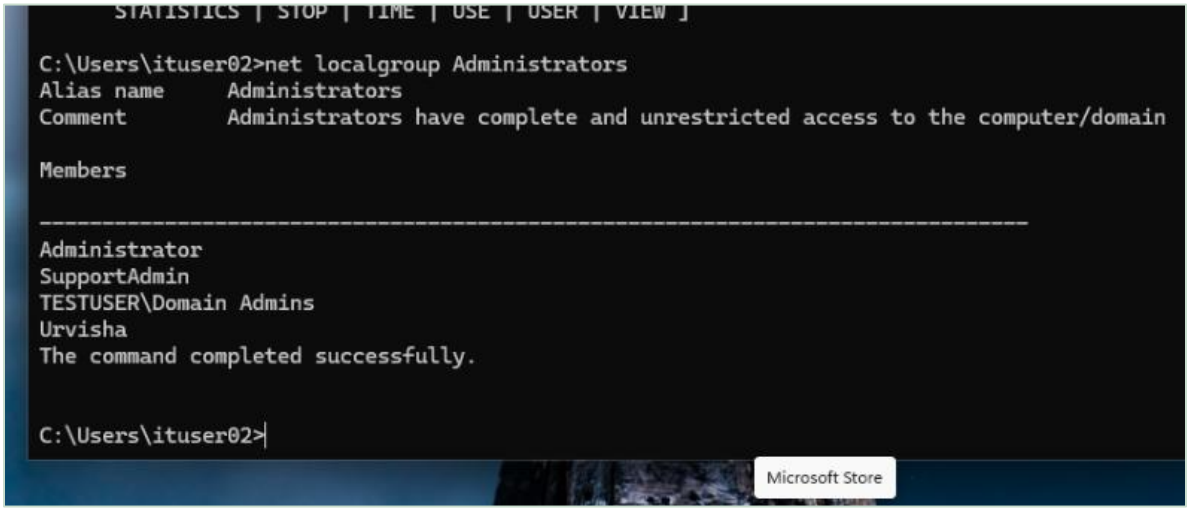


FIGURE 12 *SupportAdmin appears in the local Administrators group.*

ℹ WHY THIS CHECK MATTERED

An account being **enabled** does not make it an **administrator**. I verified SupportAdmin's group membership in two ways before relying on it for the fix.

Part C: The Fix

C1. Sign in with the authorized local admin

I signed out of IT User02 and signed in as **.\SupportAdmin**.

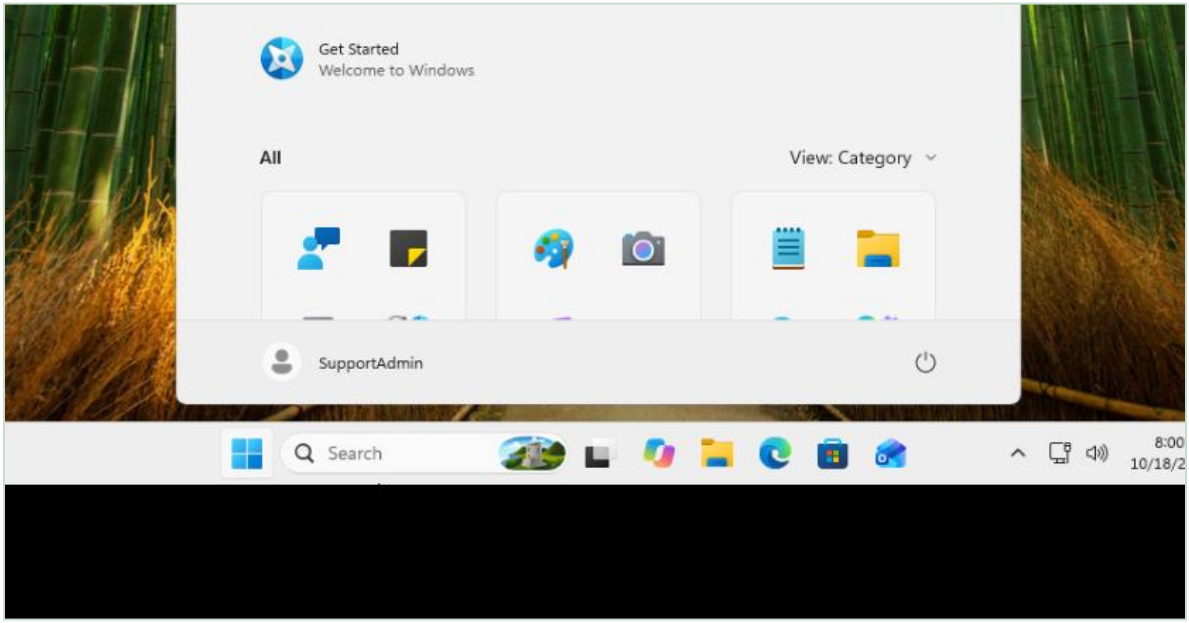


FIGURE 13 *Signed in as SupportAdmin (shown at the bottom of the Start menu).*

C2. Enable the Administrator account

I opened **lusrmgr.msc**, opened the **Administrator** properties, cleared **Account is disabled**, and clicked **OK**. This time Windows accepted the change.

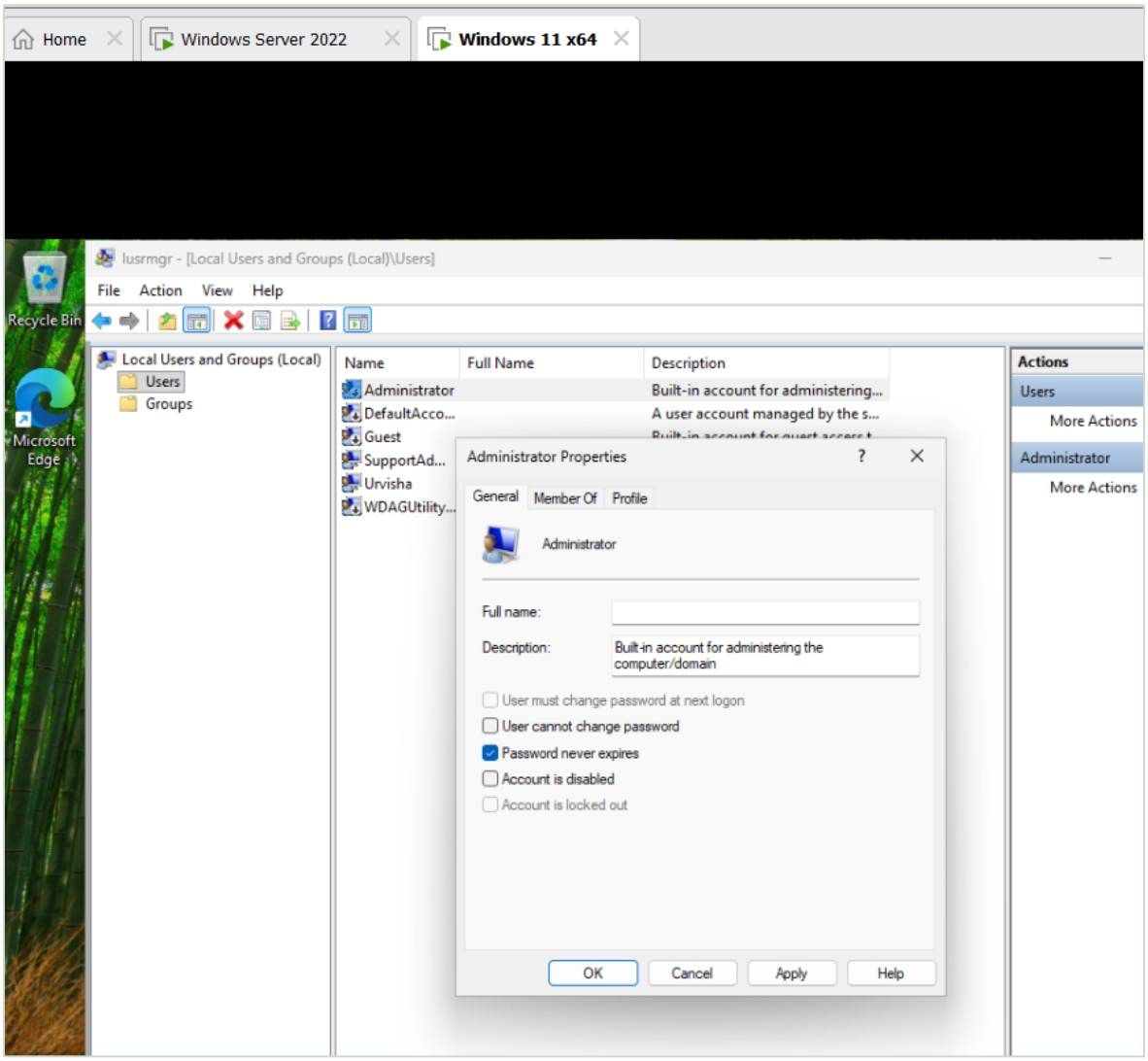


FIGURE 14 *"Account is disabled" is cleared while signed in as SupportAdmin. No access error appears.*

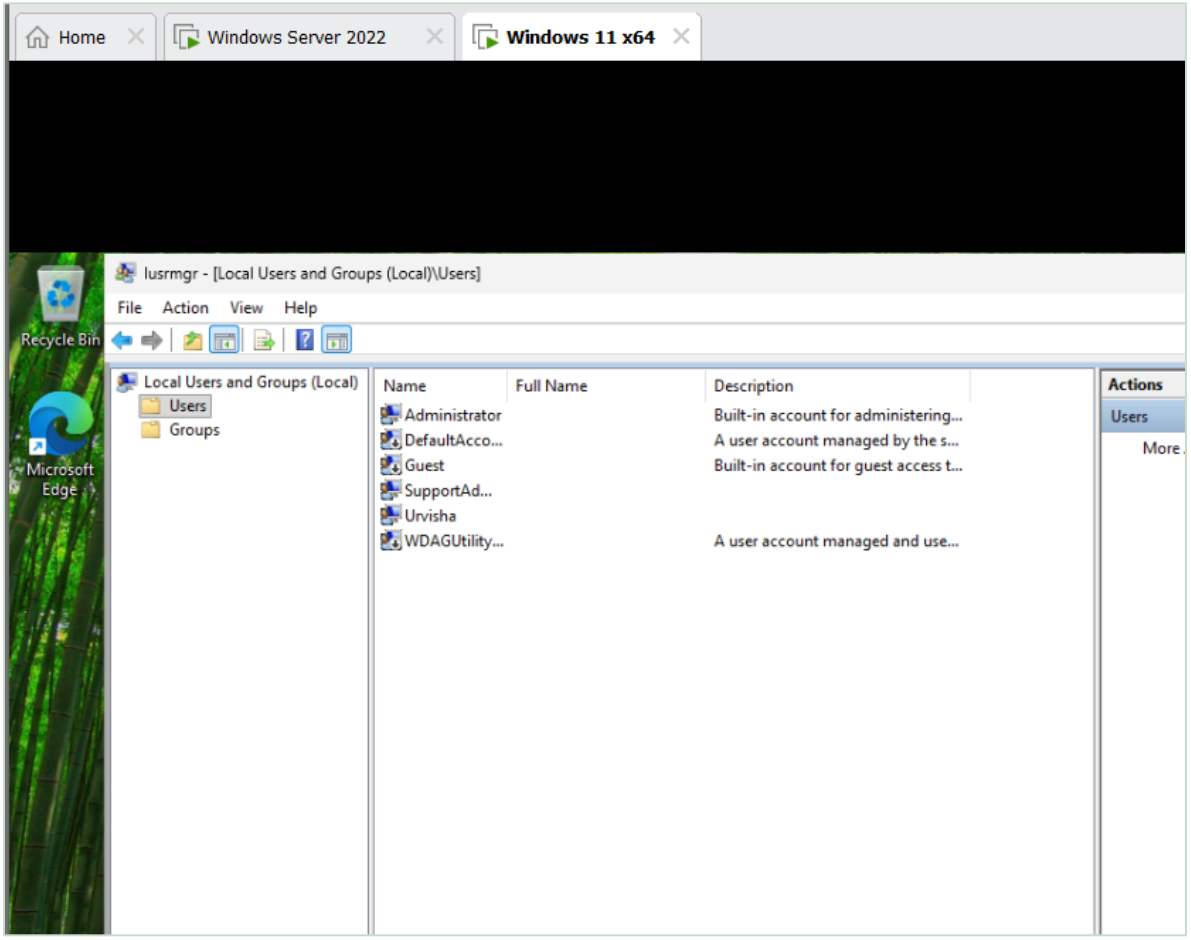


FIGURE 15 *After the change, the down-arrow is gone from the Administrator icon: the account is enabled.*

CHANGE MADE

The local Administrator account was enabled. **Its password was not changed.** Changing one thing at a time makes it possible to prove what the real cause was.

Part D: Final Verification

I signed out of SupportAdmin and signed in as **.\Administrator** with the **original** password set during the lab setup.

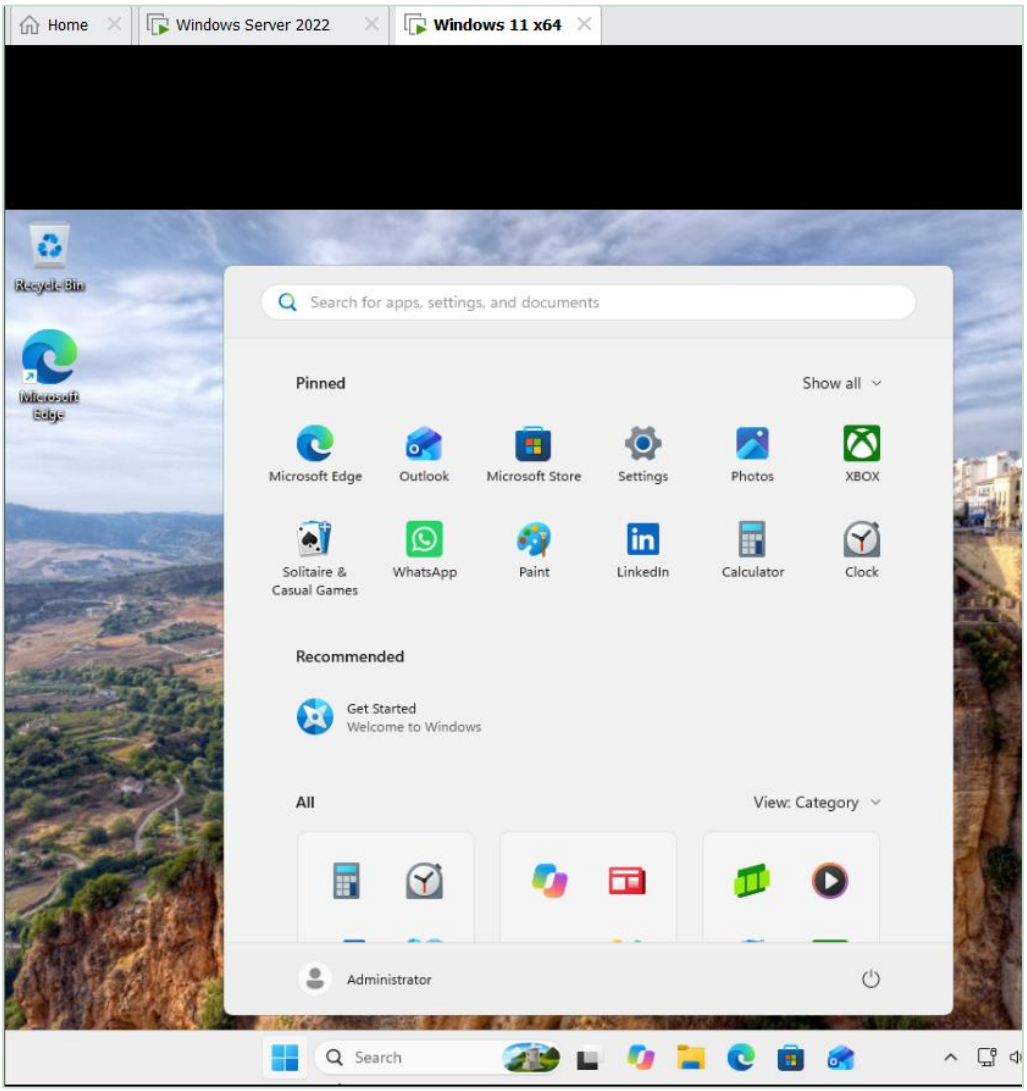


FIGURE 16 *The Administrator account signs in successfully with its original password.*

✓ **FINAL RESULT**

The account works with its existing password. This proves the disabled state, not a forgotten or wrong password, caused the failure. No password reset was needed and no data was put at risk.

Part E: Password Reset and Its Risks

Local Users and Groups also offers **Set Password** when an account is right-clicked. I opened it to document the warnings, then cancelled.

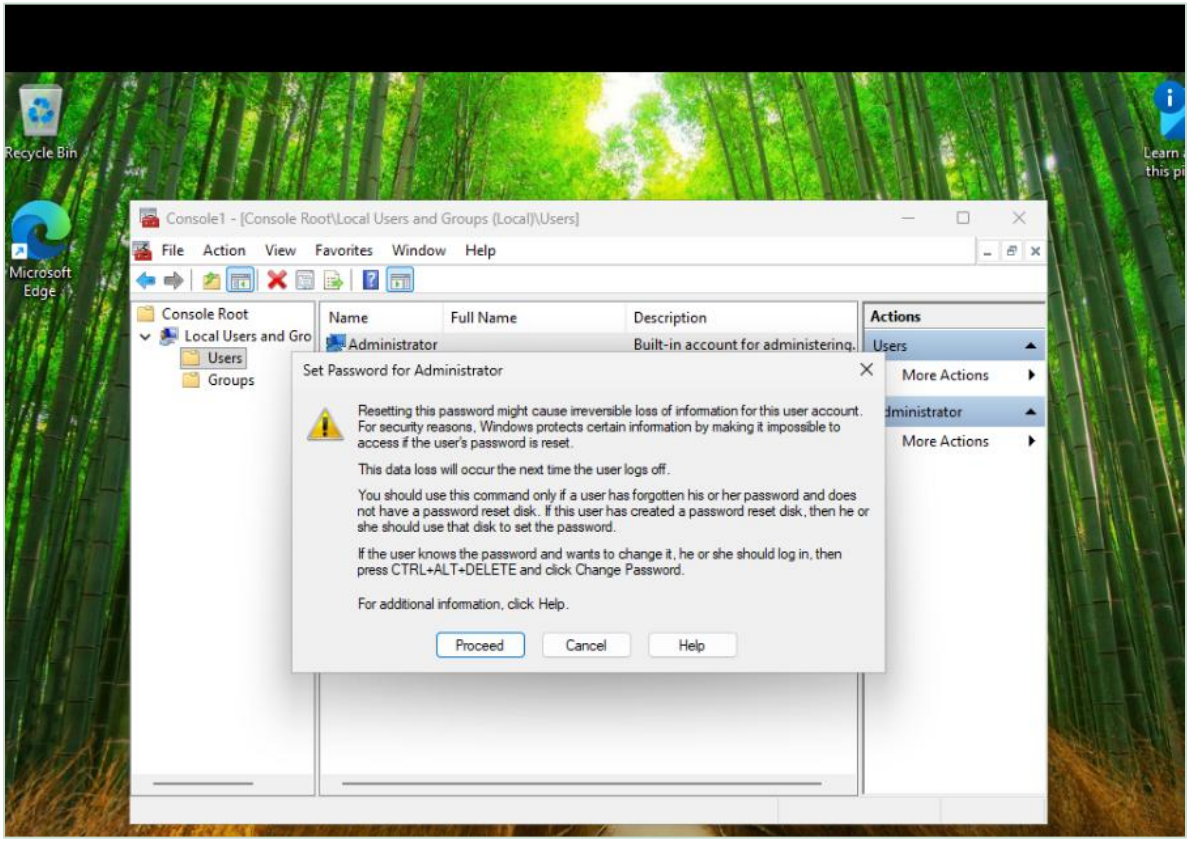


FIGURE 17 *First warning: resetting the password "might cause irreversible loss of information for this user account".*

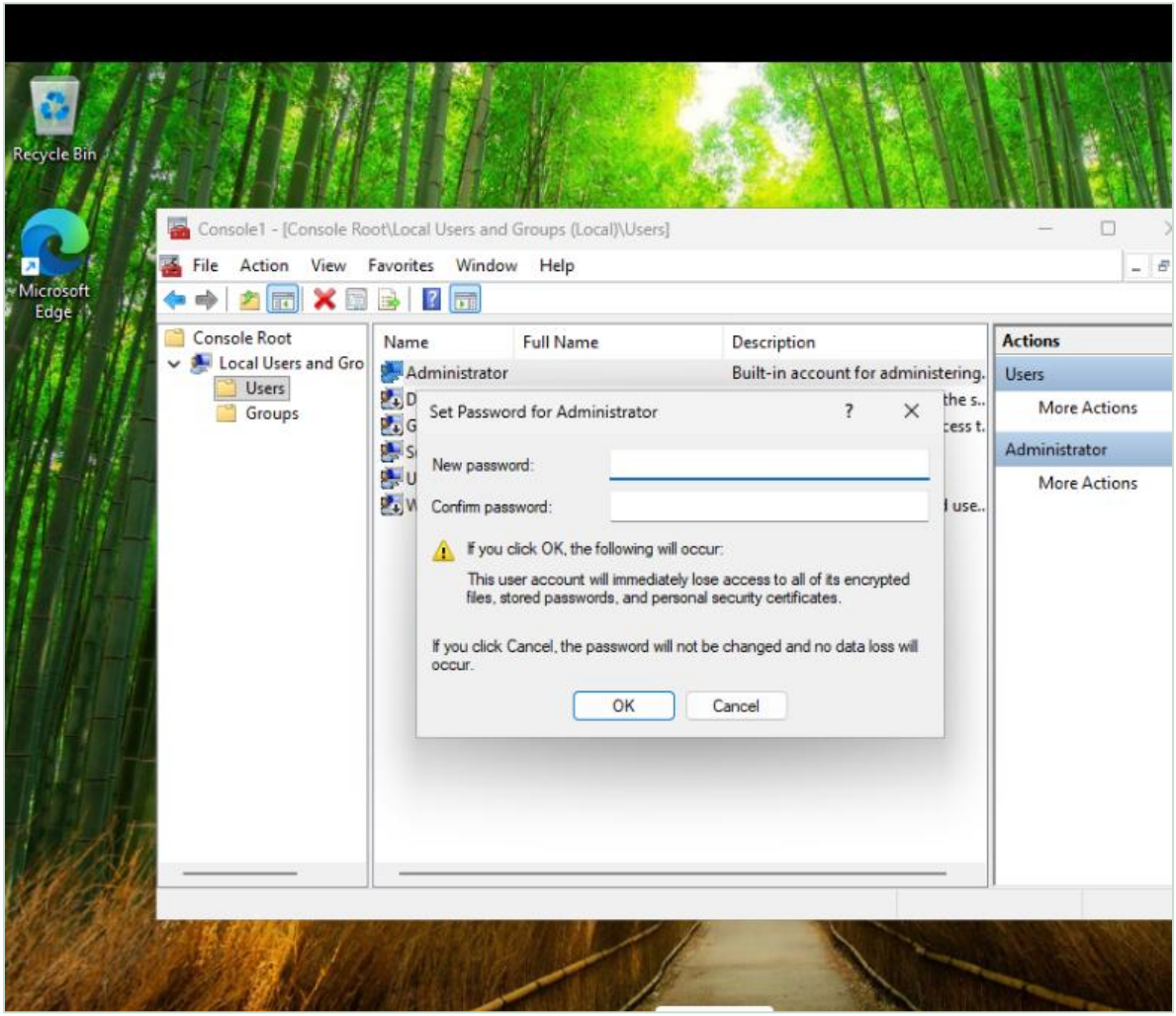


FIGURE 18 *Final warning: the account "will immediately lose access to all of its encrypted files, stored passwords, and personal security certificates".*

> **ℹ DECISION**
>
> I did not reset the password. It was unnecessary, because the original password worked, and it would have added avoidable risk of data loss.

Option	When to use it	Risk
Enable the account (used)	The account is disabled but the password is known	None to the user's data
Set Password (admin reset)	The password is truly forgotten and no reset disk exists	Loses access to EFS-encrypted files, saved passwords and certificates
User changes own password (Ctrl+Alt+Del)	The user knows the password and wants a new one	None; protected data stays accessible

Command Reference

Command	Purpose
`net user SupportAdmin * /add`	Create a local account (password prompted, hidden)
`net localgroup Administrators SupportAdmin /add`	Add an account to the local Administrators group
`net user Administrator /active:yes` / `/active:no`	Enable or disable a local account
`net user Administrator *`	Set a local account's password
`net user Administrator`	Show a local account's details (active, password dates, groups)
`net localgroup Administrators`	List members of the local Administrators group
`whoami`	Show the signed-in account
`whoami /groups`	Show the signed-in account's group memberships
`Get-LocalUser | Select-Object Name, Enabled`	PowerShell: list every local account and whether it is enabled

Graphical tools used

Tool	How to open	Used for
Microsoft Management Console	Win + R > mmc	Adding the Local Users and Groups snap-in
Local Users and Groups	Win + R > lusrmgr.msc	Checking and enabling accounts, group membership

Sign-in error messages and what they mean

Message	Likely cause
"Your account has been disabled"	Account is disabled (this lab)
"The user name or password is incorrect"	Wrong password, or wrong account type (for example `.\` instead of `.\` sends the request to the domain)
"The referenced account is currently locked out"	Too many wrong passwords (account lockout)
"Your password has expired and must be changed"	Password age limit reached

What I Learned

- **A sign-in failure is not always a wrong password.** Check the account's state before resetting anything.
- **`.\` selects a local account**; TESTUSER\ selects a domain account. "Sign in to:" on the login screen confirms which.
- **Local Users and Groups shows accounts stored on that computer**, not every account in Active Directory.
- **A standard user can view account settings but cannot change them.** whoami /groups shows why.
- **Enabled does not mean administrator.** Group membership must be checked.
- **A blank-password account cannot be enabled** when a domain password policy applies (error 2245).
- **Changing one setting at a time** makes the real cause easy to prove.
- **An administrative password reset can destroy access to protected data**, so use it only when truly necessary.

Summary and Security Follow-up

This was a local account problem on a domain-joined computer, not a domain failure. The built-in Administrator could not sign in because it was disabled. The standard domain user IT User02 could investigate but not fix it, because it is not a local administrator. I verified that SupportAdmin was enabled and a member of the local Administrators group, used it to enable the Administrator account, and confirmed the original password worked. I avoided a password reset because it was unnecessary and risked data loss.

Security recommendations

- **Keep the built-in Administrator disabled** when it is not needed. If it is enabled for troubleshooting, protect it with a strong password and disable it again afterwards.
- **Use a separate, named admin account** (such as SupportAdmin) for maintenance, so actions can be traced to a person.
- **Manage local admin passwords centrally** with Windows LAPS, so every PC has a unique, rotated password.
- **Review local Administrators group membership regularly** and remove accounts that do not need it.